UTTAR PRADESH

The Mayawati Mystery

By Prashant Srivastava and Ashish Misra

Has anyone seen Behenji? One of the abiding mysteries of the 2022 assembly election in Uttar Pradesh was the absence of the Bahujan Samaj Party supremo in what was her party's most dismal performance to date. Umashankar Singh won the sole seat for the party, in Rasra, Ballia district. Even the Congress did one seat better, as did smaller parties like the Apna Dal (S), Rashtriya Lok Dal, Nishad Party and Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party. The BSP's vote share was its lowest since 1993, a mere 12.9 per cent. It's hard to believe that this is the same party which formed a government with a full majority just 15 years back, in 2007.

Nowhere was this decline more manifest than in its erstwhile stronghold Ambedkar Nagar, which Mayawati carved out of Faizabad district in 1995. The party lost all five seats here, for the first time ever. Two of its MLAs—Ram Achal Rajbhar from Akbarpur and Lalji Verma from Katehri—as well as ex-MP Rakesh Pandey, father of current Jalalpur MP Ritesh Pandey, had left for the Samajwadi Party on the eve of the 2022 assembly election. Ritesh, a former MLA from Jalalpur, won the 2019 Lok Sabha poll, and in the ensuing bypoll, BSP lost the seat to SP. Verma, a former leader of the BSP Legislature Party, minces no words. "Mayawati has shunned the ideals of BSP founder Kanshi Ram," he says. "She is now indirectly helping the BJP. It made the people of Ambedkar Nagar angry." Now, it seems, they have spoken.

Indeed, Mayawati's inaction has left everyone confounded. Once known for her expansive voter outreach, the BSP chief did a mere 20 rallies this election season, compared to the 200-odd rallies by the BJP's Yogi Adityanath and Congress's UP in-charge Priyanka Gandhi-Vadra, and the 100-odd of SP chief Akhilesh Yadav. According to Ajay Kumar, a Dalit activist and assistant professor in the sociology department at Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar University in Lucknow, "After the BSP's ouster from power in 2012, Mayawati became increasingly sluggish. She did not show any interest in retaining the support of her leaders or the BSP voters."

Consequently, both deserted her. Of the 18 members BSP had in the assembly (after Ritesh Pandey became MP) from the 2017 election, Mayawati was left with just three MLAs just before the 2022 election. Not just sitting MLAs but even former MPs and MLAs have joined the SP in the past few years.

Hakim Lal Bind, the SP MLA from Handia in Prayagraj, who was earlier with the BSP, has this to say about Behenji's MLAs switching sides: "BSP zonal coordinators, who hold important posts in the party, asked us MLAs to make unreasonable donations to the party fund." Party tickets were allegedly contingent on such donations.

Mayawati is also accused of promoting family members—chiefly brother Anand and his son Aakash—as well as confidant and BSP general secretary and the party's Brahmin face, Satish Chandra Mishra, and his family.

Even in terms of election strategy, Mayawati's attempt to reel in the Brahmin, Muslim and Dalit votes—a



FADING PINK
Mayawati at a public gathering in Ghaziabad in UP, Feb. 3

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR